

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

Chigorin, Albin, Baltic, and Marshall Defenses

A reliable answer to Black's independent second-move defenses

TRAINING WORKBOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

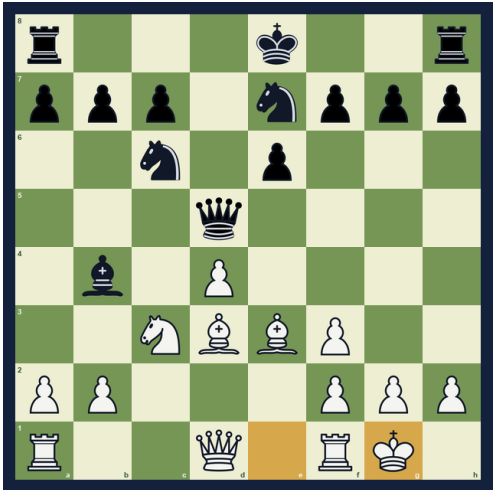
Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. Chigorin Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

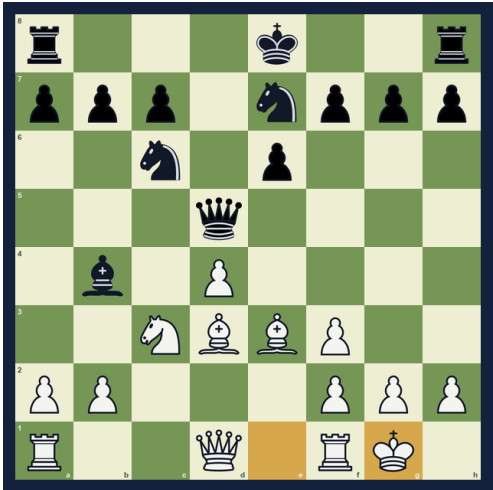
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Chigorin Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

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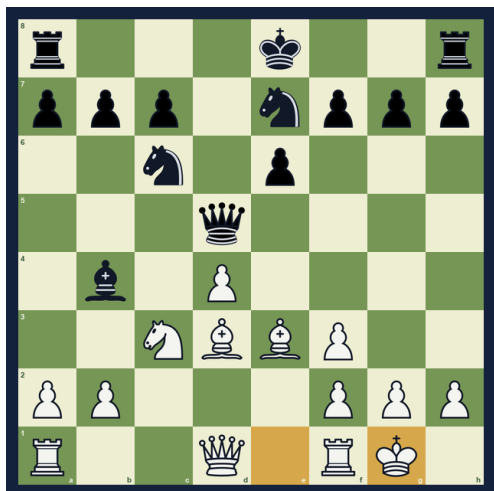
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. Chigorin Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

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4. Which piece has the least useful job?

.....

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Albin Countergambit



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. Albin Countergambit



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

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1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
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1...d5 SIDELINES

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Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

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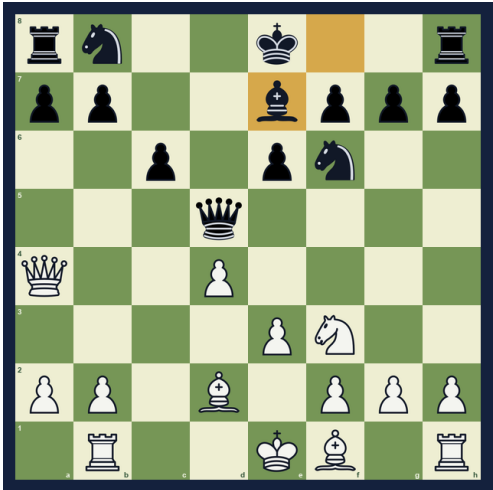
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. Baltic Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

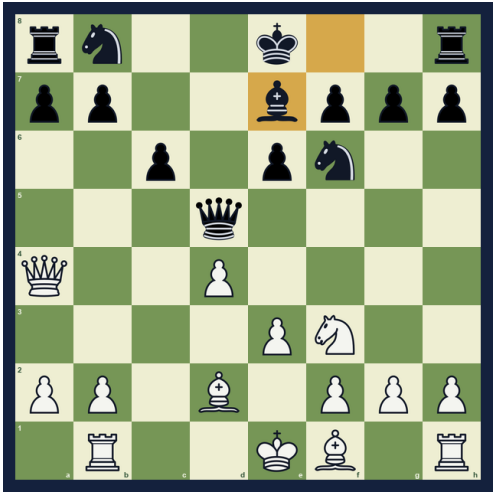
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. Baltic Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

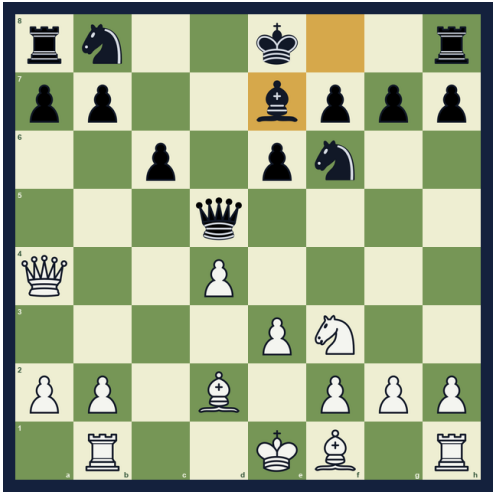
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Baltic Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. Marshall Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black plays Nf6 before supporting d5; White exchanges and gains central space by driving the knight with e4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nf6 3. cxd5 Nxd5 4. Nf3 e6 5. e4 Nf6 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 c5 8. O-O cxd4 9. Nxd4 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

11. Marshall Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black plays Nf6 before supporting d5; White exchanges and gains central space by driving the knight with e4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nf6 3. cxd5 Nxd5 4. Nf3 e6 5. e4 Nf6 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 c5 8. O-O cxd4 9. Nxd4 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. Marshall Defense



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black plays Nf6 before supporting d5; White exchanges and gains central space by driving the knight with e4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nf6 3. cxd5 Nxd5 4. Nf3 e6 5. e4 Nf6 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd3 c5 8. O-O cxd4 9. Nxd4 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

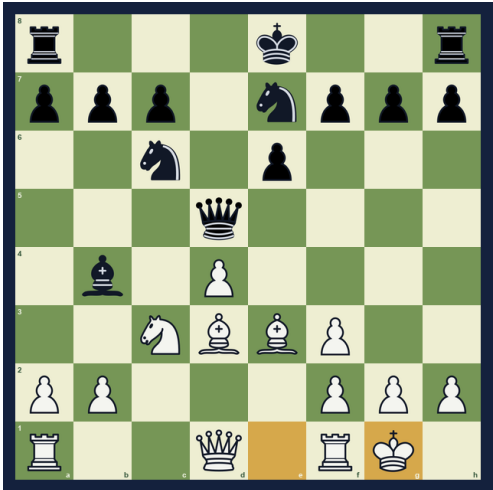
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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. Chigorin Defense - Move-Order Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

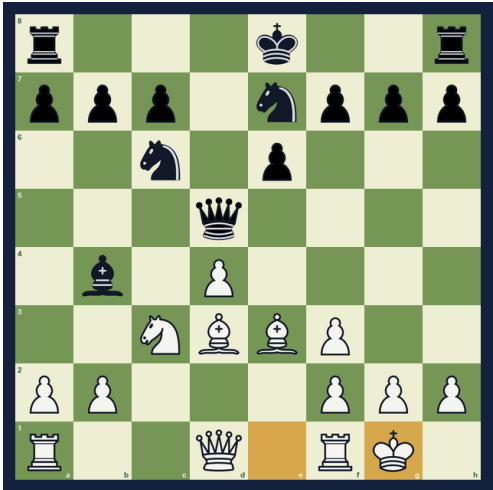
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

14. Chigorin Defense - Plan Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Use Be3 and Nc3 to attack the queen naturally.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

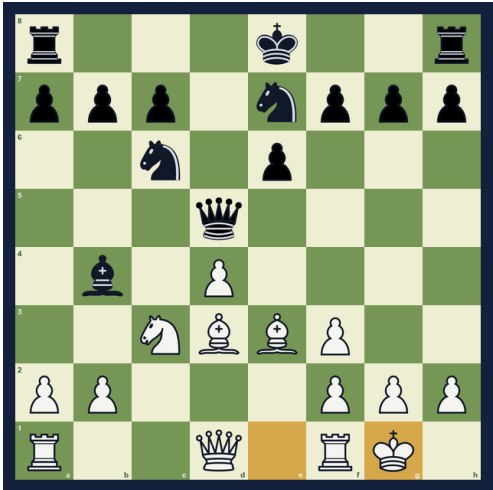
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Chigorin Defense - Break Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops pieces before supporting d5 and accepts structural risk for pressure and rapid activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3 Bb4 8. Bd3 Nge7 9. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. Albin Countergambit - Trade Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Exchange the dangerous attacking pieces before collecting the pawn, especially when Black's queen and bishops point at the king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Albin Countergambit - Move-Order Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black sacrifices e5 to drive a pawn to d4 and gain development; White restrains the advanced pawn before finishing development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Albin Countergambit - Plan Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Use Nf3, Nbd2, and b4 to contain d4.

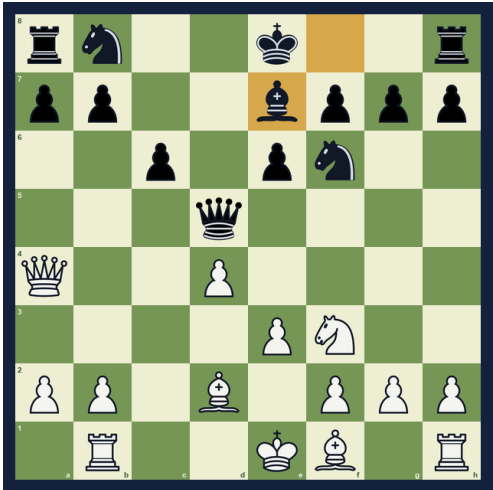
REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 d4 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. a3 Be6 6. Nbd2 Qe7 7. b4 O-O-O 8. Bb2 f6 9. exf6 Nxf6

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
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-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Baltic Defense - Break Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops Bf5 before supporting the center and grabs the b1 knight; White uses Qa4+ and Rxb1 to gain tempi against the queen.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

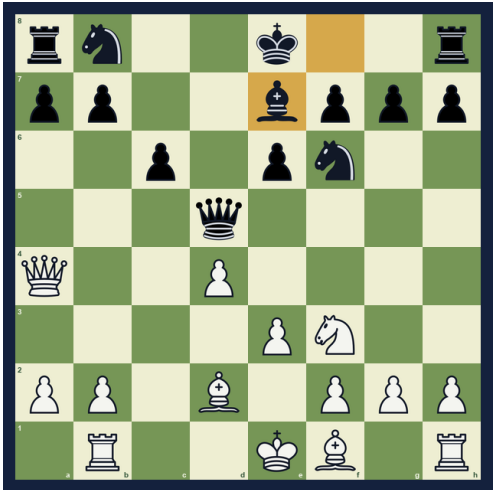
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Baltic Defense - Trade Lab



1...d5 SIDELINES

POSITION PROMPT

Trade queens only when White's development or structural edge survives; otherwise keep the initiative against the exposed king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3 e6 7. Bd2 Nf6 8. e3 Be7

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
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3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
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THREAT	__ / 2
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FORECAST	__ / 2

Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.